UCC 102 COMMUNICATION SKILLS

LECTURE 1

By the end of this module, you should be able to:

1. Define the term 'Communication'

2. State the purpose of Communication

3. Explain the advantages of studying communication comprehensively

4. Describe the nature and characteristics of communication

5. Analyse the elements in the communication process

6. Purpose of communication.

COMMUNICATION DEFINED

Communication is sharing or exchange of ideas, thoughts, and information between two or more people.

- Interpersonal and communication skills rank among the most critical for work related success.
- Effective communication occurs when the intended meaning of the sender and perceived meaning of the receiver are the same.
- Commuinacation originates from the Latin 'communicare' and French 'communis' which means common.
- This emphasizes the aspect of commonality in communication
- Thus, for effective communication, emphasis on commonality involved in any interaction.
- This means that communication interaction should result to win-win situation. This results to unity, harmony, cohesion, and sharing of aims with team spririt.

CHARACTERITICS OF COMMUNICATION.

The following are characteristics of communication;

1. Communication is a process. It is 2-way process reaching mutual understanding in which participants not only exchange information but also create and share meaning. It involves listening to others (receiving) and expressing ones message (sending).

2. Communication is dynamic. It keeps on changing depending on variables at play.

3. Communication is irreversible. Once information is communicated it cannot be called back.

4. Communication is complex. It is a process that involves all elements of communication: source, receiver, channel, message, noise, feedback.

5. Communication is unavoidable. Whenever people are together, they communicate. Others interpret what they do and say, as well as what they do not do say. Even when they choose to be silent, they are communicating

6. Communication can be formal or informal

7. **It can be verbal or non-verbal**. Verbal communication involves using speech to exchange information with others. We usually communicate verbally in face-to-face conversations such as; meetings, interviews, conferences, speeches, phone calls e.t.c. Non-verbal communication is a type of communication that employs body language.

"Body Language" is the communication of personal feelings, emotions, attitudes, and thoughts through body-movements such as gestures, postures, facial expressions, touch, smell, walking styles and positions among others. These movements can be done either consciously or involuntarily; more often they happen‘subconsciously, and are accompanied, or not accompanied, by words.

8. Communication is symbolic. A symbol is something that represents, stands for or suggests an idea. Symbols take the form of words, sounds, gestures or visual images and are to convey ideas or beliefs. It is in the message that meaning is exchanged.

9. Communication is contextual. Context affects communication- The context or environment in which a message is conveyed and received affects communication. Context refers to the relevant communication situations that influence language use, language variations given the physical conditions, emotional, social and other such contexts.

9. Noise affects communication

10. Communication has effects. For every communication there are consequences.

11. **It is reciprocal**. The sender is sending the message and the receiver is at the same time receiving the message.

12. Communication is purposive. Communication is purposive because it is done to achieve a goal for both the initiator and the receiver. There is always a motivation for communicating even when we may not be aware of it

The process of communication

- Communication can be viewed as an active process, influenced by all the complexities of human behaviour.
- It is also fraught with potential points of breakdown.
- There are many models that have been developed to simplify and aid our understanding of how communication happens.
- In this course, we look at a simple communication model. The process of communication is a very complex process and consists of eight elements which are subject to various influences.
- These elements are: sender (source), encoding, message, medium (channel), receiver, decoding, feedback and noise.
- These elements interact to determine the quantity and quality of communication.

1) The sender

- The sender is the person who has a message to be communicated.

- The sender or communication source initiates the communication process by sending a message.
- There must be a need, desire, reason or purpose for the sender to send a message.
- The source could be any individual or collection of individuals—one person, a group, or an entire organization. It could be a group of managers wanting to explain policy changes to employees, or it could be one employee explaining to another employee how to complete a certain task.

The source has three primary functions in communication:

(1) Determine what specific meaning is to be communicated

(2) Encode (translating ideas and information into messages)

(3) Transmit the message(s)

- The characteristics of the sender influence the communication process because his attitudes, credibility and other attributes influence the way he or she perceives and interpret the objects or events to be communicated.
- The sender's personality also influences the manner in which the message is transmitted.

2) Encoding

Encoding refers to the process of formulating ideas, thoughts and feelings about objects and events into words, symbols, charts or gestures and transforming them into some form of message. The way the sender perceives, organizes and interprets the objects can affect the encoding process. The sender's skills, attitude, knowledge and socio-cultural system also affects the encoding process.

3) The message

- Messages are signals and symbols used to refer what we want to communicate

- It is the outcome of the encoding process and can either be verbal or non-verbal.
- A verbal message is communicated by use of a language.
- Non-verbal communication touches the form of facial expressions, body posture, tone of voice, eye contact, touching, gestures and spatial distance.
- Non-verbal messages can affect the effectiveness of a verbal message by either distorting or reinforcing it.

3) The medium/channel

- This is the carrier of the message from the sender to the receiver.
- It is the means used to deliver the message.
- The most common medium is face-to-face conversations, telephone conversations, group conferences, written reports, charts and internal memos.
- The objective of the communication determines the type of medium to be used.

4) The receiver

- The receiver is the person who acquires the source's message.
- The receiver can be an individual, a group, or an entire organization.

The receiver has three functions:

(1) receive the source's message,

(2) decode (translation of messages into some meaning,

(3) respond to the message.

- A receiver becomes a sender when he responds to the message.
- The way the message is sent and interpreted can be influenced by: the characteristics of the message, relationship with, and the personality of the sender.

- If the receiver does not understand or share the perspective of the sender's message, he may not decode it as the sender had intended.

5) Decoding

- Decoding refers to the process by which the receiver interprets the message and translates it into meaningful information.
- When the receiver receives the message, he/she translates the message ideas, thoughts and feelings.
- The messages received are then interpreted into things or events that can convey some meaning to the receiver.
- Decoding is affected by the personal values and beliefs, perception and knowledge of the receiver.
- The more the receiver's decoding matches the sender's intending message, the more effective is the communication.
- Once the receiver receives he/she is supposed to respond to the sender- provides feedback.

6) Feedback

- Feedback is the receiver's observable response(s) to a source's message.
- Such responses can be either of a verbal nature (for example, I don't agree with you; Yes, that is right!) or a nonverbal nature (for example, a frown, shaking one's head in disagreement, nodding in agreement).
- Feedback enables the sender to know whether or not the message has been received and interpreted correctly.

7) Noise

- Noise is any factor that disturbs or interferes with the process of communication and hence in the understanding of the intended meaning of the message.
- Noise may be internal (e.g., an inattentive receiver) or external (e.g., conducting a conversation in noise of machines in an assembly line).
- The senders' attitude, assumptions and perceptions can affect the encoding process adversely.

- The receivers' attitudes towards the message and the sender can also distort the decoding process. Environmental sounds can also interfere with the transmission of a message.
- The quality of communication depends on the degree to which noises are controlled

Purpose of Communication

The purpose of communication is to ensure commonality of understanding.

Communication also fulfils other important purposes as discussed below.

1. For instruction:

- The instructive function importantly deals with the commanding nature. It is more or less of directive nature.
- Under this, the communicator transmits necessary directives and guidance to the next level, so as to enable them to accomplish his particular tasks.
- In this, instructions basically flow from top to the lower level.

2. Integration:

- It is consolidated function under which integration of activities is endeavoured.
- The integration function of communication mainly involves to bring about inter-relationship among the various functions of the business organization.
- It helps in the unification of different management functions.

3. Information:

- The purposes or function of communication in an organization is to inform the individual or group about the particular task or company policies and procedures etc.
- Top management informs policies to the lower level through the middle level. In turn, the lower level informs the top level the reaction through the middle level.

- Information can flow vertically, horizontally and diagonally across the organization.
- Becoming informed or inform others is the main purpose of communication.

4. Evaluation:

- Examination of activities to form an idea or judgement of the worth of task is achieved through communication.
- Communication is a tool to appraise the individual or team, their contribution to the organization.
- Evaluating one's own inputs or other's outputs or some ideological scheme demands an adequate and effective communication process.

5. Direction:

- Communication is necessary to issue directions by the top management or manager to the lower level. Employee can perform better when he is directed by his senior.
- Directing others may be communicated either orally or in writing.
- An order may be common order, request order or implied order.

6. Teaching:

- The importance of personal safety on the job has been greatly recognized.
- A complete communication process is required to teach and educate workers about personal safety on the jobs.
- This communication helps the workers to avert accidents, risk etc. and avoid cost, procedures etc.

7. Influencing:

- A complete communication process is necessary in influencing others or being influenced.
- The individual having potential to influence others can easily persuade others.
- It implies the provision of feedback which tells the effect of communication.

8. Image building:

- A business enterprise cannot isolate from the rest of the society.
- There is interrelationship and interdependence between the society and an enterprise operating in the society.
- Goodwill and confidence are necessarily created among the public.
- It can be done by the communication with the different media, which has to project the image of the firm in the society.
- Through an effective external communication system, an enterprise has to inform the society about its goals, activities, progress and social responsibility.

9. Orientation:

- When a new person enter into an organization, they will be unknown to the organization programs, policies, culture etc.
- Communication helps to make people acquainted with other students, lecturers and with the policies, objectives, rules and regulations of the organization.

10. Decision-making:

- Effective decision-making is possible when required and adequate information is supplied to the decision-maker.
- Everyone in the organization has to be provided with necessary information so as to enable them to discharge tasks effectively and efficiently.

11. Express feelings:

- Talking about your feelings is a healthy way to express them.

Advantages of Studying Communication Comprehensively.

- From the above discuss on the purpose of communication, it is evident that communication is an important skills that all people should acquire whether they are students, employees or managers of organizations.
- The following therefore are the advantages of Studying communication comprehensively.

1. Studying communication can improve the way you see yourself.

- Communication is "vital to the development of the whole person" (Morreale, Osborn, & Pearson, 2000, p. 4).

2. Studying communication can improve the way others see you.

- You will learn that you can to a considerable extent control your own behavior, which will lead to positive outcomes with others.
- You will find that your interactions can be smoother and that you can achieve your goals more easily as you manage the impression you make on others.

3. Studying communication can increase what you know about human relationships.

- The field of communication includes learning about how people relate to each other and about what type of communication is appropriate for a given situation.
- Most people value human relationships and find great comfort in friendships, family relationships, and community relationships.
- Within these relationships we learn about trust, intimacy, and reciprocity

4 .Studying communication can teach you important life skills.

- Studying communication involves learning important skills that everyone will use at some point in his or her life, such as critical

thinking, problem solving, decision making, conflict resolution, team building, media literacy, and public speaking.

5. Studying communication can help you exercise your constitutionally guaranteed freedom of speech.

- Freedom of speech is essential to a democratic form of government.
- Being a practicing citizen in a democratic society means knowing about current issues and being able to speak about them in conversations, in speeches, and through the mass media
- It also involves being able to critically examine messages from others.

6. Studying communication can help you succeed professionally.

7. Studying communication can help you navigate an increasingly diverse world.

Factors to consider when choosing means of communication

***a) Speed*:**

This is an important factor when the message is urgent. In such a case, telex, telephone would be the most suitable means of communication.

b) Cost:

The expenses incurred in using a means of communication differ from one means to another. Eg. It is cheaper to send messages by ordinary mail than by telegram.

c) Confidentiality:

Certain messages are intended for particular persons only. Some means can achieve this better than others.

d) Distance:

The geographical gap between the sender and the recipient is an important factor in determining the choice of means of communication. Some means are suitable for long distances while others are not.

e) Evidence:

Some means provide a record of the message conveyed. This may be necessary for purposes of future reference. All means of written communication provide evidence of message communicated.

f) Reliability*:*

This is the assurance (certainty) that the message will reach the intended recipient at the intended time, place and in the right form. Face-to-face is the most reliable means of communication because one can ask for clarity and get answers immediately.

g) Accuracy:

This refers to the exactness of the message to be conveyed by a means of communication. Written messages are generally more accurate than other means of communication such as face-to-face communication.

h) Desired impression:

At times it may be necessary to create or convey a certain impression upon the recipient. Eg. A telegram would convey a sense of urgency. The use of colourful and attractive letterheads would convey a good image of business.

NB: When choosing a means of communication, all or several of the above factors may have to be considered. The choice is however dictated by the means of communication available.